

discreetly, and often it is the poor people, consuming spurious liquor, who are at risk. This is the plight of millions across the country, but it makes news only when sufficient numbers die of it. In place of prohibition, we need a massive public awareness drive about the hazards of consuming alcohol.

VINOD C. DIXIT, *Ahmedabad*

Prohibition is an anachronism, its ineffectiveness is apparent, and its lethal fallout manifests itself frequently and in large measure. The vested interests that it has spawned are, however, too powerful to allow a change of policy. Reform is always difficult when gains from an existing system are concentrated within a select group and losses are diffused. Ideology has no role in the process.

BISHAN SAHAI,

via www.indiatoday.in

Controlled Move

Union Health Minister Ghulam Nabi Azad has been practical in his opinion on raising the marriage age to check population explosion effectively ("Control Programme", July 27). It is great that he himself is in favour of family planning despite being attacked by Islamic fundamentalists. Instead of wasting money on family planning programmes, the Government should

save public money by creating disincentives for people with large families. All government facilities and subsidies like reservation, healthcare, rations, government jobs or promotions should be withdrawn on having a third child.

MADHU AGRAWAL, *Delhi*

Right Bite

Kudos to the Board of India Today Economists (BITE) team for giving an insight into Budget 2009

SUBIR HALDER



“The Left Government in West Bengal failed due to the lack of a strong foundation at the base level. It's time the people vote the Left Front out of power.”

BHASKAR BHATTACHARYA, *via www.indiatoday.in*

("Betting on Bharat", July 20). The Budget is expected to tackle recession, give a boost to rural development and education and provide significant changes in the agricultural sector. It envisages a bold approach towards battling the economic downturn and offers steps

to simplify the tax structure, which is a good sign of development. This is definitely a realistic budget, coming at a very challenging time.

RESHMA BHAT, *Udupi*

Threat Within

Be it equipment, personnel or organisational readiness, there are wide gaps in India's security apparatus ("India Unprepared", July 20). Despite the home minister's efforts, the bureaucracy is entrenched

in the rut of inaction. Moreover, the turf wars between various security organisations and their lack of coordination may introduce fatal weaknesses in the system. Addressing these issues urgently is the need of the hour.

H.R. BAPU SATYANARAYANA, *via www.indiatoday.in*

30
YEARS
AGO IN
INDIA
TODAY

SEPTEMBER 16-30, 1979

A Fear to Remember

The cause célèbre in the capital last week was cause for embarrassment all round.

First the Janata Party consigned it to bureaucrats, then the Janata (S) sat over it, and it was out of sheer spite that, nearly four months after being submitted, the 471-page Maruti Commission report surfaced in public. Janata Party President Chandra Shekhar's tantalising threats to expose it chapter by chapter precipitated the Government's decision to hurriedly release the whole thing, and at long last Sanjay Gandhi's seamy story of building an automobile empire spilled out in sordid detail.

There was little embarrassment from the quarter under attack. A seemingly obstreperous Mrs Indira Gandhi declared two days later that she was "not worried" about the report. "I am only concerned about the country," she said confidently. "I know my path and know which path I have to take the country on." **by Sunil**

Sethi and Prabhu Chawla



**SANJAY
GANDHI AT
THE MARUTI
FACTORY**

Readers are recommended to make appropriate enquiries before sending money, incurring expenses or entering into commitments in relation to any advertisement appearing in this publication. The India Today Group does not vouch for any claims made by the advertisers of products and services. The printer, publisher, editor-in-chief and the editor of the India Today Group publications shall not be held liable for any consequences in the event of such claims not being honoured by the advertisers.

E-MAIL YOUR LETTERS TO: letters.editor@intoday.com

FAX THEM TO: 011-23316180

OR LOG ON TO: www.indiatoday.in